



QUEST NEWSLETTER

Happy New Year from the QUEST Department!
We hope you will start 2026 with a **RESOLUTION to pursue a new and exciting enrichment opportunity!**



UPMC HILLMAN CANCER CENTER ACADEMY



UPMC Hillman Cancer Center Academy's eight-week, hands-on summer program, high school students, primarily rising juniors and seniors, engage in cutting edge cancer research by working in laboratories directed by dedicated faculty at various sites across the University of Pittsburgh campus. Scholars in The Hillman Academy explore complex questions within a particular area of cancer research. The majority of their time is spent working in the lab with their assigned mentors. The remaining time is spent receiving didactic instruction; touring facilities dedicated to clinical cancer care and research; participating in journal clubs; and attending cameo presentations by accomplished professionals in the field. At the end of the program, each scholar delivers a ten-minute oral presentation and participates in a poster symposium that reflects their findings in the lab.

Visit <https://hillmanacademy.upmc.com/> for more information and to apply!

Applications are now open!

(must be over 15 to apply)

The UPMC Hillman Cancer Center Academy strives to provide cutting edge research and career preparatory experiences to a diverse group of highly motivated high school students who are pursuing higher education and careers in STEM fields, especially research and medicine. Through the



<https://www.ashg.org/dna-day/>

This contest is open to students in grades 9-12 worldwide and asks students to examine, question, and reflect on important concepts in genetics. Essays are expected to be well-reasoned arguments that indicate a deep

understanding of scientific concepts related to the essay question.

2026 Question: In recent years, new genetic treatments and therapies have been developed, such as Casgevy for sickle cell disease or Roctavian for hemophilia. Choose one genetic treatment or therapy that has been developed or widely used in recent years. Explain what the treatment is and how it works. Discuss its advantages and disadvantages. Think about ethical issues, effects on society, cost, and accessibility. If you or someone you care about had this condition, would you choose this treatment? Please explain why, considering things like age, overall health, cost factors, etc.

Important Dates

- January 9, 2026: Submission site opens
- March 4, 2026: Submission site closes
- April 24, 2026: Essay Contest results announced

Prizes:

1st Place : \$1,000 for student,
\$1,000 genetics materials grant
2nd Place : \$600 for student,
\$600 genetics materials grant
3rd Place : \$400 for student,
\$400 genetics materials grant
Honorable Mentions: 10
student prizes of \$100 each

IMPORTANT DATES:

1/1 & 1/2: No School

1/1: Registration open for summer FCAO Health, College & Finance Essentials, and SAT Prep

1/1: Register for the North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad

1/6: Keystone testing begins

1/6: Global Travel Scholars application deadline

1/7: Scholastic ART awards submission deadline

1/8: Submission Deadline: American Legion Essay Contest

1/9: US National Chemistry Olympiad

1/13: English/Social Studies/ Elective Final Exams

1/14: Science/Math/Elective Final Exams

1/15: Open heart surgery observation

1/15: End of first semester
Early graduation ceremony

1/16: No school

1/19: No school/MLK Day

1/21: ASMA Math Competition

1/23: Report cards available

1/27 & 1/28: National College Fair at the Convention Center

1/29: North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad

Questions? Email dnaday@ashg.org



L.A.U.N.C.H.



The Pittsburgh Technology Council is currently accepting applications for their summer L.A.U.N.C.H. (Learn, Aspire, Understand, Navigate, Connect, and Highlight) cohort. **L.A.U.N.C.H. Leadership in STEM Program** L.A.U.N.C.H. is a FREE dynamic program designed to empower participants to stay on the course along their STEM pathway. This is done through meaningful engagement with professionals in STEM as mentors, guest speakers on personal brand, financial literacy, entrepreneurship, and more! They will go on a series of STEM based industry tours, build peer and professional networks, and explore their potential in STEM career fields. All students get an hourly pay of \$10 each day that they attend throughout the entirety of the 2-week summer cohort. This program is open to **rising 11th and 12th grade female** students with an interest in STEM or the desire to find their ideal career pathway. Every summer there are 2 cohorts (1 in June, 1 in July) where participants meet in person Monday through Friday for 2 weeks each. Students will engage in a series of hands-on activities and complete a final project surrounding problem-solving solutions for a STEM company. Throughout the rest of the year, all L.A.U.N.C.H. alumni will be invited to a series of events including mentor meetups, book club, and volunteer opportunities. Apply early at <https://www.pgtech.org/launch/launch> for your best chance to secure a spot!

*Pine-Richland High School
presents...*



Race Day

STEAM Competition

Monday, March 23, 2026

8:30 AM – 12:30 PM @ Pine-Richland High School

2 MORE TEAM MEMBERS NEEDED!!

We will be bringing one team of 5 students to this competition. FC covers the cost of the \$100 registration fee and cost of materials (up to \$500). This year's competition, titled Race Day: Precision Braking Cart Challenge, invites students to design and test an engineering solution focused on controlled motion and precision.

Competition Includes:

- Building a precision braking cart.
- Four additional "day-of" STEAM group challenges
- One team of five students per team per school can register
- It is recommended that at least 1-2 team members have completed Pre-Calculus, as some mathematical problems may be too difficult otherwise.
- Grab & go breakfast and lunch will be provided along with prizes and awards for the winners!
- **Lisa_Gibson@fcasd.edu today if you are interested in being considered for the team.**

Teen DJ Academy with Tech25 @ the Warhol



Learn to build and blend your own DJ sets that will get everyone on the dance floor! Presented in partnership with Tech 25, the Teen DJ Academy is a 12-week workshop series taught by professional DJs with the goal of

providing hands-on experience with real equipment and opportunities to perform at Youth Invasion, LGBTQ+ Prom and other teen events. This program is free and meets on Mondays from 4-6 p.m. DJ Students will earn a stipend for attending workshop sessions plus additional stipends per performance. Participants must be ages 13-18 and space is limited.

Applications will be opening in January 2026 and available at <https://www.warhol.org/teens/> For more information please contact teens@warhol.org.



Governor's School for Global and International Studies

June 27th to July 26th, 2026

University of Pittsburgh Campus

The Governor's School for Global and International Studies prepares high-school sophomores and juniors to understand global and transnational processes through a four-week residential program hosted at the University of Pittsburgh's main campus. The program's unique curriculum and residential environment encourage students to engage with the world in a fun, intense, and immersive way. Learn more about the 2026 Governors School and apply at www.govschool.pitt.edu

International Academic Competitions

UNITED STATES DIVISION



National Science Bee

February 24, 2026
During QRT in the
Library Classroom



NATIONAL POLITICAL SCIENCE BEE

February 26, 2026
During QRT in the
Library Classroom



National Biology Bee

February 27, 2026
During QRT in the
Library Classroom



United States History Bee

March 3, 2026
During QRT in the Library
Classroom



National Geography Bee

March 5, 2026
During QRT in the
Library Classroom



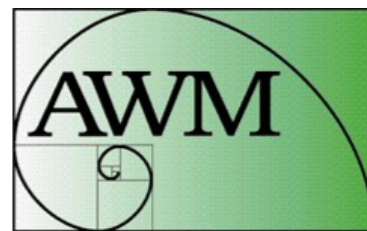
National Humanities Bee

March 6, 2026
During QRT in the Library
Classroom

The FCAHS Department is proud to host and cover the registration fees for all round 1 participants of these international academic competitions.

Further competition advancement registration and fees will be the responsibility of the student.

All interested students should contact Lesley_Cowles@fcasd.edu. Registration forms are available in the QUEST office



Association for Women in Mathematics

Women in Mathematics Essay Contest

To increase awareness of women's ongoing contributions to the mathematical sciences, the Association for Women in Mathematics (AWM) and Math for America co-sponsor an essay contest for biographies of contemporary women mathematicians and statisticians in academic, industrial, and government careers. The essays will be based primarily on an interview with a woman currently working in or retired from a mathematical sciences career.

Deadline: February 1st.

There is one First Place Winner in each category (Grades 6-8, Grades 9-12, and Undergraduate) and a Grand Prize Winner chosen from among those three First Place Winners. There are also typically 0-3 Honorable Mentions in each category.

The winners (including Honorable Mentions) receive a monetary prize, a membership in the Association for Women in Mathematics, and a certificate, and their names and affiliations are published in the AWM Newsletter. In addition, all of the essays are published online, and the Grand Prize winner's essay is published in the AWM Newsletter.

<https://awm-math.org/awards/student-essay-contest/>



North American Computational Linguistics Open Competition

NACLO - The North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad will be held at FCAHS on January 29 in the library classroom. This exam is 3 hours long and winners will qualify to compete in the International Linguistics Olympiad.

You will miss 2nd and 3rd period classes to complete the test.

This Olympiad is a contest in which high-school students solve linguistic puzzles. In solving the problems, students learn about the diversity and consistency of language, while exercising logic skills. No prior knowledge of linguistics or second languages is necessary. Professionals in linguistics, computational linguistics and language technologies use dozens of languages to create engaging problems that represent cutting edge issues in their fields. The competition has attracted top students to study and work in those same fields. It is truly an opportunity for young people to experience a taste of natural-language processing in the 21st century.

Register on the NACLO website:

<https://reg.naclo.org/>. Choose your site to be "Fox Chapel Area High School" because we are hosting the initial round of testing.

Email Lisa_Gibson@fcasd.edu to attend!

MONTOUR POETRY CLUB CORDIALLY
INVITES YOU TO THE 3RD

POETRY GRAND SLAM

SAVE THE DATE!
FRIDAY, APRIL 17, 2026

More information coming soon!

Registration Begins 8:30am

Montour High School
223 Clever Rd.
McKees Rocks PA

Made possible with the
generous support of the
International Poetry Forum



2025 – 2026 NATIONAL HIGH SCHOOL POETRY CONTEST

- Open to high school students and home-schooled students in grades 9 through 12 from anywhere in the United States
- 1 – 2 poems with a maximum of 40 lines each
- No entry may have been previously published
- Winners will receive a monetary prize, a signed copy of Matthew Shenoda's latest book, recognition at Gannon University's 49th Annual Writing Awards Night, and publication in Gannon University's award-winning literary journal, *Totem*.
- Winners and Honorable Mentions will be notified in March
- Submit poems by February 1

For more information, contact: highschoolpoetry@gannon.edu

AWARDS

First Place: \$50

Second Place: \$40

Third Place: \$30

Berwyn Moore Young Erie Poet Award: \$50

SUBMIT POEMS HERE:



GANNON
UNIVERSITY

FOR FULL GUIDELINES AND TO SUBMIT, PLEASE VISIT
WWW.GANNON.EDU/POETRYCONTEST

APPLY FOR CARNEGIE MELLON'S SUMMER ACADEMY FOR MATH & SCIENCE (SAMS)

SAMS is a pre-college program that provides opportunities for rising high school seniors who are underrepresented in STEM-related fields. SAMS is a fully funded, merit based program.

To be eligible for the SAMS program, students must:

- Be at least 16 years old by the program start date.
- Be a U.S. citizen or permanent resident.
- Be in 11th grade at the time of application submission.

"From my time at SAMS, I learned so much about myself and college and met some of the most incredible people. This has been the best 6 weeks of my life, and this program is one I couldn't recommend enough."
-SAMS 2025 Participant

Program Dates: June 20 - August 1, 2026

Deadline to Apply: February 1, 2026

Decision Notification: April 15, 2026



cmu-sams@andrew.cmu.edu

Carnegie Mellon University
Center for Student Diversity
and Inclusion



The Pennsylvania Restaurant & Lodging Association Educational Foundation (PRLAEF) is excited to host a one-day hospitality workshop on **March 18** at The Westin Pittsburgh! Designed for students in grades 9–12, this hands-on event will introduce them to the energy, creativity, and endless opportunities within the hospitality industry. Students will get an introduction to the hospitality industry with a full day of learning and career exploration.

Learning outcomes: Create awareness of hospitality career pathways within culinary arts, baking/pastry arts, hospitality management and tourism sectors. Explore technical skills for entry level foodservice application with hands-on demonstrations. Demonstrate communication strategies that are necessary for successful employment within a global workplace.

Students who are interested in attending should email Lisa_Gibson@fcasd.edu



Stop the Violence Black History Month Essay Competition

THE TOPICS FOR OUR 2026 ESSAY CONTACT WILL BE:

- Who is Dr. Carter G. Woodson and why did he start BHM
- Name one Black person you believe is important to American history

Student Essay Competition:

This essay competition will be between Students in Grades 9-10 and Students in grades 11-12 in each school division created by this program. Winning categories for 9th and 10th grade students will include 1st, 2nd and 3rd place winners with appropriate prizes for each school division. Winning categories for 11th and 12th grade students will include 1st, 2nd and 3rd place winners with prizes for each school division. All 1st place winners, grades 11th and 12th, will then compete for the final Western PA Grand Prize which will include a new category of 1st, 2nd and 3rd place winners. Student division winners will receive 3rd place-\$50 gift card; 2nd Place-\$75 gift card and 1st Place-\$100 gift card.

Essay Contest Rules

1. All Essays shall be 300 words or less.
2. Essays shall be written in 12-point font Microsoft word or comparable font, double spaced with 1-inch margins.
3. Each essay shall include a Title, Student name, School, Grade and Teacher's name.
4. Essays will be judged on:
 - * Quality of writing
 - * Grammar, spelling & punctuation
 - * Essay organization (strong and organized beg/mid/ending)
 - * Topic understanding (writing shows strong understanding)
 - * do not Cut and Paste
 - * do not Plagiarize
 - * NO AI generated essays will be accepted

5. Essay Submission is due on or before, January 30th, 2025.

Essays should be mailed to:

STVP c/o Student Essay Contest,
1106 Success Street,
Pittsburgh, PA 15212

or emailed to:

StoptheViolencePgh@yahoo.com

Student winners will be announced and awarded on
Wednesday February

10th, 2026, 9:30am to 1pm, at the Student Black History
Submit at

Soldiers & Sailors Memorial Hall
4141 Fifth Ave., Auditorium
Pittsburgh, PA 15213



2026 College Fair
D.L.L. Convention Center

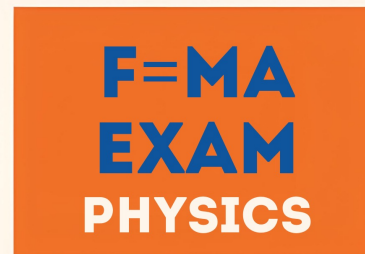


Join us at the 2026 College Fair, a premier event taking place at the David L. Lawrence Convention Center on January 27-28, 2026. This exciting two-day event is designed to connect prospective students with representatives from a diverse range of colleges and universities from across the country. Whether you're a high school student exploring your options or a parent seeking information, this fair offers a unique opportunity to gather valuable insights and make informed decisions about higher education.

Attendees will have the chance to engage in one-on-one conversations with admissions officers, attend informative workshops, and participate in panel discussions covering a wide array of topics, from financial aid to campus life. Discover the perfect fit for your academic and personal goals, and gain a deeper understanding of the application process. Don't miss this chance to explore your future and take the first step towards your college journey. With so much to offer, our College Fair is an invaluable resource for anyone considering higher education. Mark your calendar and prepare to embark on an exciting path to your future!



February 12, 2025 **ONLY!**



- Exam Begins at 2:00 p.m.
- Students will be dismissed at 1:45 and need to complete a permission form (released early February, in the QUEST Office - 168).

Register with Dr. Cowles: Lesley.Cowles@fcsd.edu

Registration Deadline: **January 23, 2025**

**Five-minimum student needed to run the event.
Ten-maximum student are able to participate.**

Luminari Award today. Our merit-based award is open to all students in 7th - 11th grades who want to hone their writing skills while competing for a scholarship to our annual diplomacy program. Winners of the competition are named *Luminari Award Scholars* and are invited to attend the *I Want to be an Ambassador!* summer camp.

All students may enter the award on their own by submitting their applications and essays directly to us in an easy 1 - 2 - 3 process:

1. **Write a one-page essay** describing your interest in diplomacy and the ways in which you will benefit from the *I Want to be an Ambassador!* camp in your daily life.
2. **Sign the application** and have your parent or legal guardian sign it as well.
3. **Return the completed essay and application** to luminari@luminari.org or mail to: Luminari, P.O. Box 81603, Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania 15217 no later than February 15. The winner will be announced in early March. We look forward to reading your essays. Good luck!

____ Applicant's Name
____ Street Address
____ City
____ State Zip
____ Cell Phone
____ Email
____ School
____ Grade Birth Date
____ How did you learn about this scholarship opportunity?

If I am selected to be a Luminari Award Scholar:

____ I agree to attend all sessions of the *I Want to be an Ambassador!* camp.

____ I will arrive on time, be prepared to participate fully and abide by the rules of conduct as set by Luminari.

By signing and returning this application, I acknowledge that I have read and understood it, and I agree to the terms and conditions above.

____ Applicant Signature Date
____ Print Applicant's Name
____ Parent/Guardian Signature Date
____ Print Parent/Guardian Name
____ Parent/Guardian Phone Number

Please attach your one-page essay on diplomacy with this application form and email to luminari@luminari.org

Tom Berich

Operations Manager

www.luminari.org

412-877-1888

tom@luminari.org



WESTERN PENNSYLVANIA
LEARNING ACADEMY
presents

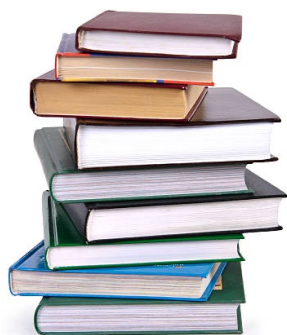
SAT[®]



Sunday, March 1, 2026

Noon – 5 p.m.

Fox Chapel Area High School LGI



- Test taking and time management tips
- Intensive grammar & usage skills review
- Intensive math skills review
- Critical reading skills and strategies
- Practice drills with actual test questions
- Experienced and highly-trained instructors



This program is most suitable for students who have successfully completed Algebra 2.

Please bring with you a graphing calculator and laptop.

Contact Lisa_Gibson@fcasd.edu if you do not have access to these items.

****PRE-REGISTRATION IS REQUIRED****

Student Name: _____ Grade: _____

Student Email: _____ School District: _____

Mailing Address: _____

Parent/Guardian Name: _____ Phone: _____

Parent/Guardian Email: _____

Please make checks payable to Fox Chapel Area School District (FCASD).

No refunds issued after February 25, 2026

*Submit check and completed registration form (front and back)
either in person (Fox Chapel Area High School room 168) or via mail to:*

Lisa Gibson, Director
Western PA Learning Academy
Fox Chapel Area High School
611 Field Club Road
Pittsburgh, PA 15238

The well-being of any child is a parental responsibility. In an emergency, every effort will be made to contact a parent/guardian. Please list two persons who can arrange transportation and care for your child when you are not available.

Relative or Friend: _____ Phone: _____

Relative or Friend: _____ Phone: _____

WESTERN PENNSYLVANIA LEARNING ACADEMY

Program Permission Form



Student Name: _____

I, _____ give permission for my child to attend the assigned date of the Western Pennsylvania Learning Academy's SAT Boot Camp. In the event of an emergency, if treatment is required and parents/guardians cannot be notified immediately, I give consent for emergency treatment and transport to the nearest emergency room.

Does your child have any health concerns that would hinder participation in the field experience? _____ No _____ Yes. If yes, please complete the following:

Please indicate if your child has any of the following health concerns:

_____ Asthma _____ Inhaler needed
_____ Life-threatening allergy to bee sting _____ EpiPen
_____ Life-threatening allergy to food _____ Benadryl needed
_____ Seizure disorder _____ Diabetes
_____ Allergy to _____ Other _____

Emergency Treatment (if needed): _____

Health Insurance: _____

Family Physician: _____ Phone: _____

My signature confirms that my child has permission to participate in all activities on the specified dates. Permission is also granted to share this information with appropriate academy personnel.

Parent Signature: _____ Date: _____

Cell Phone #: _____ Work Phone #: _____

Cancellation policy:

We understand situations arise when you may need to cancel your reservation. To do so, we request you notify us at least 24 hours in advance. This allows us to offer your slot to another student on the waiting list. Cancellations or rescheduling requests made less than 24 hours before the event may be subject to a cancellation fee of 30%. No-shows without prior notification will not be refunded.

In case of emergencies or unforeseen circumstances, please contact us directly to discuss your situation. We may be able to waive the cancellation fee at our discretion.

Fox Chapel Area Online Summer 2026 Course Offerings

Open to students currently enrolled in grades 9, 10, and 11.

Online courses run for 5 weeks from

Friday, June 12 through Friday, July 17

Application deadline: February 28, 2026

FCAO Career and Financial Essentials



For students entering grades 11 or 12, **Career and Financial Essentials** complements all disciplines and other standards by developing postsecondary goals regarding career planning and financial literacy. Students will embark on a career search, compose a job application, and develop a personal résumé. Students will also learn about consumer skills, debit/credit, budgeting, and taxes. The culminating experience is a one-on-one professional interview that will be conducted in the fall. All activities are completed online. Assignments are due weekly, but students may work ahead, if desired.

.5 credits

FCAO SAT Prep



For students entering grades 11 or 12, **SAT Prep** helps students strengthen their skills using Khan Academy's SAT Practice modules to build test readiness. Students will complete two full-length, timed SAT practice tests to simulate real testing conditions and track their progress. Lessons focus on improving performance in Reading, Writing, and Math. Additionally, students learn test-taking strategies, including familiarity with the Bluebook testing app utilized by College Board. Weekly assignments help students stay accountable and steadily improve their scores.

.5 credits

FCAO Discovery Health



For students entering 10th grade, **Discovery Health** allows students to apply wellness concepts to the study of the human body. Utilizing basic facts about the body systems, students will discover how daily decisions can impact the operation of the human body. This is a required course for graduation from FCAHS. It meets the PA State Standards for Health, Safety, and Physical Education. All activities are completed online. Assignments are due weekly, but students may work ahead, if desired.

.5 credits

**** These are compressed courses. Students are completing an entire course in five weeks. ****

Frequently Asked Questions:

What is the format of these classes? These classes are fully online & asynchronous, with weekly due dates.

What if a student is on vacation for part of the 5 weeks? Students can choose to work while on vacation or complete their assignments ahead of time. The late work policy will apply to all students, regardless of travel plans, so it is important to plan accordingly.

What is the late work policy? Late work is accepted up to one week with a 20% penalty; no work is accepted beyond one week late. No work is accepted beyond the last day of class, Friday, July 17th. The expectation is that all students will follow the course schedule due to the compressed nature of the classes.

How much should be expected for these classes? These classes are the same semester-long classes compressed into five weeks.

Can a student take more than one course? It is possible, but the student should consider their schedule and availability to complete multiple semester courses in a five-week span.

How do I register? Spaces are limited and classes get full. Spots are filled on a first-come, first-serve basis. A student isn't enrolled until the form AND check are received. No refunds are available after June 1st.

**Fox Chapel Area Online
Summer High School Course Registration
Courses run from June 12 – July 17
Open to students currently enrolled in grades 9, 10, and 11
Registration Deadline: February 28, 2026**

I would like to register for the following summer course(s):

- ☐ FCAO College and Career Essentials (grades 11 & 12), \$200.00
 - ☐ FCAO SAT Prep (grades 11 & 12), \$200.00
 - ☐ FCAO Health (grade 10), \$200.00
-

Student Name: _____

Current Grade Level (circle): 9 10 11

Student Email: _____@student.fcasd.edu

Student Phone : _____

Parent/Guardian Name: _____

Parent/Guardian Phone: _____

Parent/Guardian Email: _____

***SPACE IS VERY LIMITED!
STUDENTS ARE NOT ENROLLED
UNTIL REGISTRATION AND PAYMENT ARE SUBMITTED.
NO REFUNDS after June 1, 2026.***

Please make check payable (separate check per course) to:

Fox Chapel Area School District (FCASD)

Submit check and form either in-person (high school room 168) or via mail to:

**Lisa Gibson
FCAHS Summer School Registration
611 Field Club Road
Pittsburgh, PA 15238**

Contact Lisa_Gibson@fcasd.edu (412-967-2479) with any questions.